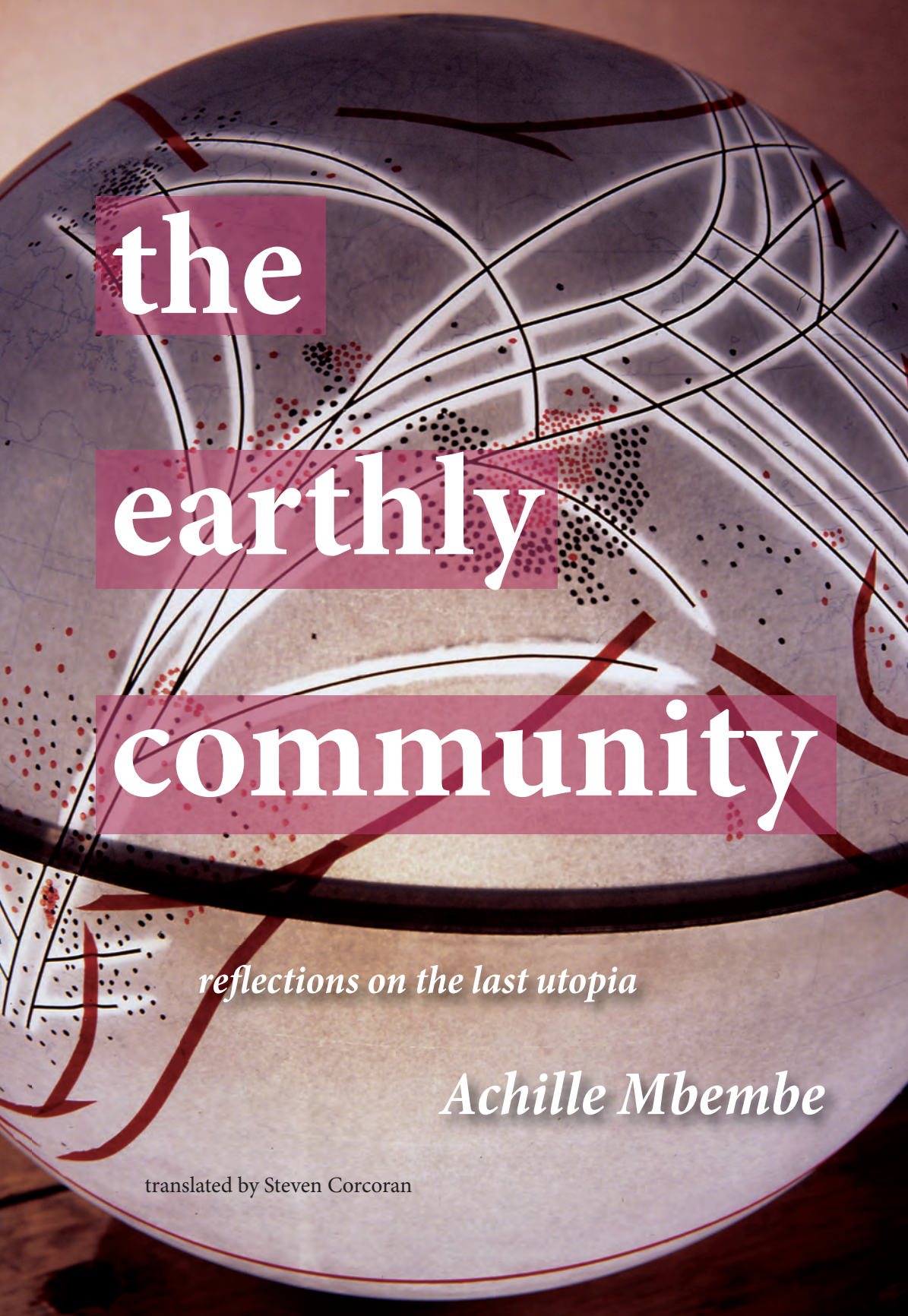


The background of the cover is an abstract composition. It features a central, slightly off-center, light-colored circular area that resembles a globe or a planet. Overlaid on this are numerous thin, dark, curved lines that intersect and crisscross, creating a network-like pattern. There are also several thick, dark, curved lines that sweep across the frame. Scattered throughout are clusters of small dots, some in red and some in black, which appear to be concentrated in certain areas, possibly representing cities or data points. The overall color palette is muted, with shades of grey, white, and dark brown, accented by the red and black dots.

the

earthly

community

reflections on the last utopia

Achille Mbembe

translated by Steven Corcoran

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foreword

The present reflections bear, in a general way, on the Earth, its becomings, and above all on the kind of community or collective that it forms with the cohort of animate and inanimate species that inhabit it, have found refuge in it, or sojourn on it. We must thus, when treating the Earth, bear in mind the living world in its entirety and its innumerable manifestations. Of this Earth, humans, together with animal, plant and mineral species, as well as microbes, bacteria, and viruses, seas and oceans, skies, climates, technological devices, and other artificial and externalized apparatuses, are an inseparable part.

forces of becoming

Also an inseparable part of it—at least according to the animistic metaphysics of the ancient Africans—is the living in its myriad richness: all the invisible and obscure forces, the genies, the ancestors, and their substitutes, together with the spirits and masks, red fibers, clothes and jewelry, cowrie belts, long-handle calabashes and baskets of sesame, dances and ceremonies, funerals and festivals. Not all these things are of the same kind and they are strictly speaking different entities. But each in its own way is a *sketch of the living*.

Amos Tutuola's 1952 novel, *The Palm-Wine Drinkard*, paints a striking picture of these metaphysics, of these very different ways of thinking, of

thinking other things, of thinking differently to the ways that we, that many, have wrongly deemed assignable to “inferior societies” in recent times.¹ Significant in this respect is how these latter societies distinguish between what is possible, what is probable, and what is plausible. This is the work performed, for example, by divination.² All that is true and real participates in one or other of these categories to a varying degree. Some events occur. Others do not. Still others are likely to occur, but nothing guarantees either the possibility or the probability of their occurrence. Some establish themselves as probable. Others do not. Essentially, nothing formally prohibits anything at all from coming to pass. In return, nor does anything guarantee this coming to pass. There is no absolute impossibility.

There is nothing passive. Nothing is mere continuous repetition of the same. Everything is radically approximative. Taken in isolation, no entity, or subject, has full control over its freedom and destiny. Time is unending. But while its sweep is unlimited, inexhaustible, it is made of segments, of different branches. For its part, life has an arborescent quality and thus contains a multitude of possible futures. It is not only woven of uncertainties but randomness is part of its “egg cell.” Life, as a dice game, is always exposed to disintegration. As every risk threatens gnawingly to turn into an existential risk, the living subject is one that is prepared for incessant mutations and is ever able to change its state.

When unlinked from one another, each of the collectives, entities, and objects that makes up the living is perishable, putrescible, liable to succumb, and each of these events is furtive and ephemeral. Placed together, these sketches are transformed into dynamic assemblages. Thus coming to life, they become so many of the Earth’s mirrors, and contribute to social durability. Because they are open to each other, made for each other, the Earth thus assumes the properties of a vibratorium: a scene that is at once solar, nocturnal, and lunar. The Earth is a sort of *binder*; it makes possible the passage from one form to another—metamorphosis.³

According to these sorts of metaphysics, the Earth has vibratory, corporeal, sensory, and carnal properties that pre-exist those of human beings. The Earth’s body and flesh figure in them as counterparts to the body and flesh of the multitude of beings that compose it or that it hosts. The Earth

thus is, like all bodies and flesh, fungible and perishable. In permanent contact with matters of death, it runs the risk of decomposition, like the deceased under a red shroud. The Earth can attain unlimited duration, but only if it is capable of fecundity and regeneration. In the absence of this capacity for periodic (re-)begetting, it amounts to no more than the darkened mask of a vast house of the dead. This is why, among ancient Africans, interrogations into the Earth's becoming, or into technology's destiny, often took the form of a long meditation on the theme of seeds, sowing, and germination.⁴

For, if there is one enigma that most myths and ancestral knowledge strive to solve, it is that of knowing how to pass from one world to another, from one form to another, and, in so doing, to give life to what is threatened with demise. This function was assigned to techniques and other objects, beginning with the mask as the eminent and indeed first form of commemoration of the dead. It was also assigned to liturgical materials, such as throwing sticks, or the stones or those on which the newborns are placed for their official naming, those on which the sanctuary's wooden statues rest, or the turtles said to represent an ancestor, or even the snake that comes of a night to lick and clean the priest.⁵ Techniques are *utensils of life*. Their role and that of objects is to increase energetic potential and thereby to help humans complete themselves, augment their strength, and establish a link between restoring themselves and restoring the world. Thanks to techniques and objects, it was believed that the mysteries of that secret language, the secret of death, could be penetrated, and that the various metamorphoses that precede the sowing festival could be endured.⁶

Among all the brutal changes that affect the living in this age on Earth, two in particular deserve to be examined from viewpoint of the animistic dialectic of seed, germination, and sowing. The first, thanks to the world's ongoing combustion, concerns the possible exit from the climate niche in which humans and non-humans have thrived for the past six thousand years.⁷ For, though the planet's regions are not impacted equally or to the same extent, overheating is real everywhere. Oxygen is now hit by scarcity. The radical vulnerability of bodies can no longer appear as accidental. It is that by which we are composed, that through which life itself happens.

As the planet becomes ever smaller, the utopia of limitless growth will run its course. Study after study shows that, if nothing is done, we will inevitably reach thresholds, lethal thresholds, resulting in heat exchange blockages, protein deformation, the destruction of muscle cells, and poor blood circulation. But this will jeopardize more than the human body's cooling mechanisms.⁸ The Earth's body itself, and its vital organs, will fail in an interconnected chain.

The second change concerns the world into which we have already entered. This world will be mostly dominated by computational reason. Gigantic computing devices will be to the twenty-first century what the alliance of steel and concrete was to the nineteenth and twentieth centuries.⁹ In other words, technology is going, more than ever before, to be one of the *fundamental forces* of our world. It will provide this world with a semblance of unity, but will also drag it into a process of splintering and endless fragmentation. In this respect, technology will leave a profound mark on the world's future. More than this, it will be our environment, the territory in which we move, our *biotope*. It is thanks to and through it that new imaginary territories and new languages will appear, that the living will have its coexistence organized, that other ways of making or breaking the world will emerge. In addition to computing devices themselves, countless mega- and nanostructures will come about whether through EHV lines, energy infrastructures, or a multitude of satellites placed in orbit and all sorts of relay antennas.

Everything will therefore revolve around technology. If technology were to close in on itself, it would cease to be the pledge of life and restoration of the human species to which it aspires. For the time being, it continues to lend to our feelings of prodigiously accelerating speeds, of the exponential expansion of time, of the dilation of space and even the cosmos, and of the almost limitless irradiation of energy flows required for earthly existence—it has become the new magnetic field of all earthly existence. In the beginning, the energy flows necessary for life on Earth came directly from the sun. Very early on, human communities learned that if they could exert enough pressure on the natural environment, it was possible to extract from nature and appropriate part of the Earth's primary production. Gradually,

they worked to replace game with livestock, gathering with crops, and the extraction of wood from the forest with silviculture. They intensified thus the controlled production of biomass, and eventually moved from subsistence farming to modern, production-oriented agricultural systems.

Moreover, since mastering fire, humanity has continually turned to other, always more powerful and energy-intensive sources. This is how the major leaps from one civilization to the next have occurred, right up to nuclear civilization. Certainly, in many parts of the world entire communities still rely on wood burning to convert energy into food.¹⁰ And there are other places in which domestic animals and human populations continue to produce energy using muscle power, leaving the sun to do the rest.

mutant powers

For the most part, however, since the domain of machines tends to prevail over the reproduction of life, the norm is fossil-fuel dependency—a dependency on resources that accumulated in the ground over millions of years. This norm is partly what has gradually enabled nuclear fission to serve in weapons and energy use. However, humanity's entry into the nuclear condition has not come without a cost. This cost is precisely radioactive contamination¹¹—a contamination that continues apace and is extending its grip on the planet across all national borders.¹²

What account can be given concerning today's vast acceleration of fires, or the marked increase in virus alerts and other health disasters? Computing devices, which now feature in the daily experience of millions of human beings, are not only gadgets used for surveillance and capture. They foreshadow the advent of a new form of power. Let us call it *mutant power*. Its properties are invisibility and, often, undetectability. This power is fundamentally predicated on the predation of the living. Mutant power has a twofold dimension: radioactive (irradiative) and viral (parasitic). It moves either by irradiation or in the viral mode. Concerning the former, radionuclides, as Sabu Kohso remarks, “travel far and for a long time.” They “permeate the Earth in an elusive and chaotic nano-dimensional pattern,” and “the genetic

mutations they generate are hereditary.” As for viruses, they can only travel short distances and for a short time. But “infected cells spread coextensively to all humans through the dispersion of body fluids (aerosols and microdroplets) or direct contact.”¹³ Mutant power, in the course of its spread, produces sometimes non-organic (or machinic) effects that are dispersed in space and time, and sometimes organic effects that directly attack social relations.

Populated by processors, cameras, and objects connected to all sorts of surfaces, including the body, the world into which we have already entered hatches and feeds a regime of existence in which automated systems collect and process innumerable amounts of data on our every act, desire, and behavior. Mutant power also acts through *enclosure*, including even where it claims to be ensuring the protection of lives. Vital activities then become subject to technopolitical management. Such measures generally consist in isolating infected bodies and placing drastic restrictions on social life, including physical interactions between bodies. Mutant power indeed registers more through what it destroys than what it protects. It can eradicate all desire for truth. So doing, it turns politics into an existential struggle where everything comes down either to protecting or losing one’s life. In other words, politics is now lived out at the intersection of several catastrophes, the nature of which is techno-informational, radioactive, viral, and techno-environmental.

Although flesh-and-bone bodies, microbes, and bacteria still play a part in reality, our existence, or much of it, tends to play out on screens, and most gestures are robotically guided. Whether we are talking about video games, e-commerce, or pornography—that is, all manner of artefacts, media, and applications—a large part of everyday life unfolds thanks to the ready availability of sites, as great in number as the tales they peddle, in a world that is increasingly mobile, in the most polymorphic, viral, and cinematic sense of the term.

All this means that the forces of becoming—whether virtual or actual—are now, more than ever before, born by a *constellation of technical beings*. Technology is generally the name given to this constellation and its modes of operation. The term refers not only to an assembly of objects, tools, ma-

chines, and instruments, but also to an institution and an imaginary that extends to the world's most invisible peripheries. There is a tendency to forget this. The *technological* is *prima facie* an archetype of the *artificium*, of the *artificial*, of that which, as *manufactured*, is the result of combinations of skill and ingenuity. But it is also, in itself, a regime of meanings, even a constitutive dimension of the fabulist imagination. In this sense, it is the exact opposite of the natural domain, with which it nevertheless shares the attributes, properties, and functions of use and utility. But what ultimately determines the technological today is not so much its artificial properties as its *android status*.

Technical objects do not only provide mediation between the human and the natural and supernatural worlds. In reality, human *be-ing* itself gets materialized in the technical object. Human *be-ing*, that is, delegates some part of humanity to the object, which thus becomes the human's double, its recipient. Endowed with a part of the human's humanity, the object is transformed into *a being in its own right*. It is no longer a pure assemblage of matter. It is now vested with intentions, as an expression of the human being's desire for mastery and power. Yet, while the human lends part of its own individuality as a living being to the object, the latter nonetheless acquires an autonomous existence. From its own interior, the object transforms into a generic vector of indetermination.

This is the sense in which we could interpret what Gilbert Simondon calls "the presence of man in machines."¹⁴ "The human," he claims, is not only the inventor of machines, their living interpreter, or "the organizer of a society of technical objects."¹⁵ The human is "*among* the machines that operate with them" and, according to an animistic metaphysics, *in them*.¹⁶ Insofar as it can be said that "what resides in machines is human reality, human gesture is fixed and crystallized in structures that function."¹⁷ Conversely, the claim can also be made that a part of the human consists in the reality of objects. The human is not only among or in machines; machines, in turn, elaborate the human, pass through it, and move into it. This is what gives machines their android character.

three paradoxes

Three paradoxes, however, lie at the heart of our technological present. On the one hand, the question of technology as an expression of the *forces of becoming* has increasingly been severed from the political questioning of the *sense of that becoming*. Instrumental reason and the power it generates no longer bear the burden of meaning. Driven by profit, they have notably freed themselves from all judgement and now suffice unto themselves.

Thanks to the triumph of pure force over meaning, everything happens as if all possible futures depended almost entirely on the ability to manipulate tools, objects, and instruments. The only real would seemingly lie in that which has practical functionality, with immediate utility being the decisive word of all things. As the real is now defined by the mere law of use and utility, intelligence itself gets reduced to a simple recipe. Technology thus becomes the repository of both the most obscure human desires and what remains of human and historical will. It no longer merely frames flows. It no longer simply vests all kinds of organs. It marks bodies, all bodies. It is on the point of becoming the *second body of the Earth*.

On the other hand, there is no longer any doubt that thermo-industrial civilization will eventually drive the planet to exhaustion. Abetted by financialization and technological escalation, humanity's predatory capacities have greatly intensified, further envenoming inter-species relations. From this, a dramatic involution has ensued and a profound dissociation arisen between technological reality and social-political thought. This occurs at a time when technology, along with ecology, should rather be the privileged terrain of new political struggles.

A third characteristic must be added to these two. Technology now tends to take on all the attributes of religious thought, of magical or animistic reason, as well as of aesthetic activity. Until relatively recently, it was presumed that the artificial object made humans more remote from the real world. Now the artificial object is a vector of potential fusion with it, since the world itself has become artificial. Hence, to inhabit the world means to engage uninterruptedly with matter, forms, and objects. It means immersion

in sensible existence, in a direct relationship with the world—a relationship without mediation, one that is consciously material and objectal.

This integral participation in the life of objects and matter, this fundamental adherence to the law of utility, means that contemporary humans live in relative co-naturality with technology. The corollary of this lack of mediation between the human and the material world is the exhaustion of symbolic reserves. Technology comes to fill the vacuum thus created. Doing so, it seizes hold of the functions formerly assigned to transcendence, donning a timelessness that establishes it as one of the last universal religions. This religion, however, unlike the classical ones, is Godless.

By virtue of this, we may well be witnessing the almost definitive triumph of gesture and artificial organs over what André Leroi-Gourhan called speech. This end of speech—the wholly definitive triumph of gesture and artificial organs over speech, or fact that the history of speech may be closing before our eyes—is the “historial” event par excellence. In this context, can the question of governing the Earth be grasped simply through the categories of social anthropology inherited from the nineteenth century? To what extent does the digital density of the contemporary human subject and its relationship with the animal, mineral, and vegetable world, as well as with the rest of the living world, oblige a way of thinking about the Earth that is no longer based on the old separation of subject and object, of the useful and the useless, of that which counts and that which does not?

These questions emerge as different modes of violence are being tried out on the world’s population. The accumulation of brutalities meted out by state apparatuses (army, police, immigration systems, criminal justice) does not fail to include all countries. In addition to this visible and increasingly spectacular violence, however, there are other more insidious, delayed, slow, and indirect forms. Both sorts of violence, spectacular and indirect, are combined in technology, which is essential to the development of affluent societies, whose myth it also sustains. In return, even if, from time to time, this myth recognizes the devastation caused by technological escalations, technological development in itself is persistently framed as a history of uninterrupted improvements and thus of human emancipation.¹⁸

This quasi-automatic reinscription of the technical object within an emancipatory trajectory has led to the negation of the very idea of planetary limits. Technological acceleration is deemed able to help us overcome every limit to growth, including even land availability or non-carbon energy. For every natural resource consumed, some artefact can simply be made to replace it. As Rémi Beau observes, for example, the search is on to substitute “natural materials with synthetic materials and direct withdrawals of food-stuffs from nature with the consumption of agricultural and livestock products.”¹⁹ Within this purview, the solution to the anthropocenic is indeed technology itself. Technical systems can be used to supply the same services that the planet’s ecosystems fulfill. The resources necessary for life would, then, no longer be drawn from nature. Understood in this way technology remains within the instrumental horizon in which a certain tradition of Western thought has long effectively confined it. Might technology, as a set of devices enabling us to act on nature in order to transform it, thereby lose its disruptive power, its power to capture, to transform the things of the world into energy? Or, by contrast, might it sanction the supposed separation of the human from the other forms of life that make up nature? This is one of the major questions at the center of this essay.

chapter one

the universal right to breathe

Recently the split between the production of tools and the production of symbols and, above all, of speech has been pointed up. The case has notably been made that the tool has taken precedence over the word, instrument over meaning, force over sign. There are three advantages to taking Africa as the starting point for an investigation into the becoming of the Earth and the destinies of technology.

general ecology

First, Africa is a region of the world from which a theory of life and a theory of ontogeny emerged whose potentialities we have not yet fully exploited. As Amos Tutuola explains in his novel *The Palm-Wine Drinkard*, here, in Africa, almost everything is variation, life included. Nothing is ever identical with itself. Sizes, external forms, internal structures, environments vary constantly, even and especially when they are intertwined in interdependent processes. The living itself is recognized by its variability and unstable structure, a property that is not the equivalent of disorder or anarchy. On the contrary, the tissue of the living is formed through differences in expression. And this tissue is open to multiple recombinations. Any such order is, by definition, *plastic*.

In *The Palm-Wine Drinkard*, originality, ambiguity, and singularity take precedence over identity, while random events outweigh essentialism, fixity, and determinism. In it, history assumes the structure of a die. Actors constantly change their identities and positions. Metamorphoses, transpositions,

mutations, and rearrangements are the norm. No entity is static. Instability is part of an entity's architecture *and* its functioning. New entities arise through processes of continual combination and recombination. Indeed, the living can only ever have an order imposed on it that is artificial. Its structure is not cellular. It is formed on the basis of a potential for variability, elasticity, and plasticity. This potential is what gives the living its molecular constituents. Such is general ecology.

At the heart of this ecology, two activities—namely the making of artefacts (in other words, tools, instruments, and images) and the production of symbols—have always proceeded from one and the same flesh, the flesh of language. What is common to tools, images, and instruments, on the one hand, and to signs and symbols, on the other, is that they are *utensils of life*. Moreover, as far back as we go in history, human existence in Africa has always had a fundamentally ecological dimension. Ecology was the very source of language and its ultimate destination. The great diversity of environments was matched, as if in echo, by the great *diversity of beings*. For the ancient Dogon, for example, the multitude of beings included humans, genies, invisible things and powers, the souls of the ancestors, and other realities associated with life, such as the heat of fire and the sun, ants, termites and birds, plant fibres, masks, and even words themselves.¹

These beings were divided into several categories. Of these categories, three in particular—human beings, immemorial and night beings, and the artefactual beings produced by technology—were linked to each other through synergistic relationships. Similar to groups in other parts of the continent, the Dogon considered each being to be in itself the cause of its own movement. But this same movement could, moreover, be set in motion by an external force. Speech was a case in point, its value was matched only by the constant danger it represented for every speaking being.² Each category of being was also engaged in a multiplicity of actions simultaneously. Acting and perceiving were, in fact, inseparable. Peering, glimpsing, and seeing were in themselves ways of acting on, with, and through the world.³

All beings made multiple uses of the environments and milieus in which they lived, uses that made sense only in relation to the general struggle against death. Moreover, human life and death were part of one and the

same story, one and the same framework. These original myths, rites, and systems of thought were preoccupied with a single enigma: the introduction of death into the world. Which resources could be garnered to check the corruption and threats to the disappearance of not only the human but the living world in general? This struggle against death, that is, to restore and continually renew the universe, was organized “with elements that were partly immaterial, partly material.”⁴ For the rest, being alive required the deepest immersion in a spatio-ecological framework. This immersion had the distinction of allowing close communication with other universes, including the cosmic and that of plants. The material control exercised by humans over the environment, that is to say, the organization of its matter, was performed through all kinds of techniques, including cults and rites. The environment could be exploited and transformed. But every ecological environment was above all a universe in which beings of all kinds learned how to move.

This way of *making the world through moving and resonating with the other forces of the living* gave prominence to a diversity of forms of know-how. These forms aimed at understanding what was hidden and at bringing the invisible within the reach of humans. Forms of know-how and objects were considered to be a guarantee of life. Further, learning consisted above all in listening to the landscapes and their surroundings, to topography (*relief*) and sacred places, to lines and fringes, to the cycle of the seasons, to myriad sounds and images, and to the glebe. The basic question was indeed how to decipher the signs of life, the thousand paths of the living, to capture life flows and ensure life’s redistribution along its various chains—mineral, botanical, zoological, psychological, biological, and organic.

For that matter, the various categories of beings wove relationships with each other that were not limited to human society.⁵ If there was a *secret*, it lay in the shift from one state to another. And this secret of knowledge could be acquired only after a gradual unveiling, at the end of a long initiatory journey. The society of humans was merely a singular segment of *the general community of beings, which included the dead*. Further still, technical processes were by definition a part of all vital processes.⁶ The ultimate function of technical objects was to participate in life’s irradiation and possibly also in

reaffirming the cosmos. Life itself was understood both as an energy that circulated between singular bodies and myriad environments *and* as the capacity to actualize the profusion of possibles.

Second, Africa is one of the oldest and youngest laboratories of the living in the history of the human species. It is where humanity as a species first became aware that a certain future would open up ahead if it freed itself from the animal condition, that achieving this could not be left to chance, and that continuing to grow and reproduce would require the addition of gesture to speech and a marking of its own memory by making tools.

Added to this realization was another—and this is the third advantage—namely that species transform, or else are fated to disappear, and that technical objects are one of the major keys to this transformation. Technical objects are not simply means by which humans objectify nature. By producing artefacts, humanity also objectifies itself, materializing its desires and intentions as well as its constructive and destructive power. In short, through technology it projects its sensible qualities onto materials. This is how humanity set itself in motion, releasing a whole range of possibles in the process. All this transpired long before humanity came to understand that atomic processes could be used to end its earthly adventure. Indeed, when brought to its maximum point of incandescence, the technical object, a human creation, can be turned into an instrument of humanity's suicide.

Among the ancient Dogon, two archetypal figures came to express this fundamental ambivalence: the ant and the termite. The ant, by devouring seeds, destroyed life. It was a bearer of death. It was simultaneously a sign of life, because metamorphosis was thought to characterize its biological cycle. Its corpse did not rot but dried out. The termite, by contrast, mainly fed on plant debris, and thus on dead substances. In so doing, it destroyed death while simultaneously connoting it, since it did not metamorphose during its biological cycle. Furthermore, a dead termite mound exuded a particular odour comparable to that of a corpse.⁷ In both cases, there is a clear dialectic between dissolution, decay, and the perishable body, on the one side, and metamorphosis and transposition, on the other. In both cases, the emergent question is one of sustainability.

In this schema, the Earth is grasped not so much through a contrast with the stars, or relative to its multiple geological ages and epochs. Instead, and from an expressly political and symbolic point of view, it is perhaps to be understood as the *ultimate, or last, utopia*. The Earth is indeed, in its minor sense, a global unit of subsistence, a material and social resource whose conquest and appropriation, redistribution and development give rise, almost everywhere, to multiple, and sometimes existential, conflicts.

Isn't the Earth, more than any other identifier, associated with stories of origin and feelings of belonging and affiliation, with myriad identity neuroses and the mythology of blood, soil, and kinship? As a source of food, a place to work, an alienable commodity, a taxable object, or a place of burial, isn't it everywhere liable to be used in varied fashions, or to be the object of fixations, occasionally even lethal ones? Doesn't making it one's own require occupying it, settling on it, and defending it against other potential occupants? In many respects, it appears in the final analysis to be a power of underpinning that cannot be shared, since two distinct peoples cannot own it simultaneously.⁸

There is something about the relationship to land that, beyond its expanses and reliefs, its lines and depths, makes it a primitive source of dispute, one preferredly dealt with by force. As appropriable, land is the sort of good that arouses a desire to dispossess others of it for one's own benefit. This is undoubtedly why, in the name of defending or conquering it, there is a willingness to shed blood and inflict death—one's own and that of others. Through effective occupation, the right to govern is transferred unreservedly. This is what happened between 1870 and 1900, when Europe seized the last colonial territories, first by signing "treaties" with non-state power structures along the African coast—thus acquiring "legal titles" that were not really titles at all—and then by proceeding to "fully effective occupation" through conquest. In his *Nomos of the Earth*, Carl Schmitt refers in this regard to the Congo Act (1884–1885). On the pretext of "open[ing] up the only part of the globe it has not yet reached, piercing the darkness, [and] enveloping the entire population," civilization undertook, in the words of King Leopold of Belgium, "a crusade worthy of this century of progress."⁹

This is one reason why peoples whose land has been taken mostly fall under foreign rule. After the sword has passed through and blood is paid, by preference against blood, sovereignty is wrested from these peoples and their lands are proclaimed “leaderless, even empty.”¹⁰ Every colonization or bloody adventure has involved precisely this—a given land is declared virgin or uncultivated, and its occupants are confined to reserves, the typical example of an enclosure and some gaping elsewhere.

By likening the loss of land to a loss of limb and worse, acts of dispossession or expropriation have fuelled many revendications in return. These revendications have generally aimed at obtaining reparation or restitution. In this way, acts of dispossession have been met with demands for justice. Justice, in this most elementary sense, consists in returning what is owed, in recovering what is lost, in preventing theft and usurpation. The thief and the usurper are precisely those who have unjustly taken something essential from others but have themselves suffered no offense.

Inscribed thus into the Earth’s very foundation is the right to reclaim it as that which belongs to us. But this foundation is also that which our works are based on, the ground without which we remain as if voiceless, deprived of air and water and left suspended above the void. This right to restitution or reparation is inseparable from the right to defend yourself, which derives ultimately from the supreme duty to *take care of yourself*. For many earthly communities, this injunction is among those that the Earth bears: take care of yourself.

land grabs

Yet the terms of land ownership change constantly. In the second half of the twentieth century, powerful multinational companies kick-started a frantic land grab. Millions of hectares of land were the target of massive alienation. Once used for subsistence farming, this land is now given over to the trade in food raw materials. Some lands have been allotted to logging and producing agrofuels such as soya, sugar cane, palm oil and jatropa, which is processed into oil for industrial products. Tens, if not hundreds of

thousands, of hectares have also been earmarked for rubber or maize plantations. Abetted by financial speculation, combined occasionally with support from international institutions, a new plantocracy is emerging due to the transition from food crops to agrofuels. Thanks to these same international institutions, and on the basis of unequal agreements, the assets and financial investments of this plantocracy are protected against political risk.¹¹

In addition to large agricultural areas as such, rare metals and other natural resources are also targeted. This is especially true of forests, water, and minerals. The seas are not left untouched. Powerful private interests are taking ever greater control of coral reefs, coastal shores, estuaries and lagoons, deltas, wetlands, and mangrove forests. The seabed cannot elude capture either.¹² All this means that entire populations, which once lived from fishing, are deprived of their means of subsistence. The way is slowly opening to the financialization of the oceans.

This financialization has been enabled thanks to giant farms of salmon and shrimp, as well as various types of drilling. Financialization also impacts the immense carbon stock of coastal ecosystems, marshlands, mangroves, and seagrass beds. The financial markets offer “blue bonds” on top of the already existing “green bonds,” the idea being that only under the aegis of large-scale financial capital can we best protect the oceans and best govern marine resources.

In addition to these latter changes, it should be noted that a handful of powerful companies are gradually wresting control of halieutic resources. This control is achieved by monopolizing production chains, starting with fish farming (salmon, Nile perch, fresh red tuna, fish oil rich in omega-3, and so on), shrimp farming, or canned food processing. For the rest, the capture or “extraction of fisheries resources relies largely on deep-sea fishing engaged in bottom trawling, which destroys the seabed.”¹³ A few large retailers and multinational fishing companies (Marine Harvest in Norway, Nippon Suisan Kaisha in Japan, Pescanova in Spain) have effective control over the entire aquaculture market. Ever greater numbers of carp, tilapia, pangasius, clams, shrimp, and salmon are being farmed. These farmed fish and shellfish are then dumped into freshwater systems and oceans where they threaten wild fish populations. As a result, ecosystems are set to suffer

lasting degradation. As one commentator put it: "Pollution generated by the discharge of chemicals, faeces and fish feed into the aquatic environment—anti-fouling chemicals, antibiotics, colorants, and tons of nitrogen and phosphorus—promotes the growth of toxic algae."¹⁴

It doesn't stop there. Technological laboratories are increasingly engaging in interspecies breeding, a rarity in nature. They are creating new transgenic fish in specialized tanks, for example, by transmitting an eel gene to half-salmon half-trout fish. Biotechnology laboratories are performing the same transgenic procedures on animals by genetically modifying species such as pigs (with a mouse gene), chickens, goats, and rabbits.¹⁵ The great glaciers are not invulnerable either. In Antarctica, for example, warm currents filter down into the circumpolar current and attack the ice beneath the surface. The ice shelves themselves are constantly losing surface area and volume. A huge part of the ice sheet has been permanently weakened. A rise in sea and oceans levels is thus an inevitability.

Also intensifying is the exploitation of subsoil resources, at least when the land holdings acquired are not being used as collateral for the purpose of speculating on carbon markets. Huge areas of land often located in countries already beset by hunger and poverty, have been annexed for intensive industrial farming. A new class of landowners has emerged that consists of private and public companies, states, sovereign wealth funds or investments for the production of soy-based diesel, energy from biomass, or for the trade in metals or food commodities.

At the same time, while multinational biotech companies are busy patenting and privatizing conventional seed varieties, many governments are withdrawing from the management of gene banks. This lays the path forward to the progressive privatization of seed conservatories. Thereby ancestral knowledge is disappearing that, for centuries, has allowed for the selection of varieties that fit local needs. A large variety of organic agriculture is thus also disappearing along with this knowledge. Importantly, these shifts must be set in the context of the technological intensification of production methods. At issue here is not so much the freeing of nature from the ties that bind it to humans, as the eco-modernist current of thought, among others, claims. Still less is it about renewing our thinking about nature con-